interact with leading luminaries from all over the world. A few months later, the Royal Bank of Scotland (RBS) made a bid for ABN AMRO, and, in 2007, acquired the bank for $99 billion. In the process, RBS became the largest bank in the world.

At this stage, I was offered a global role in RBS, but chose to stay in India as the CEO and Chairperson of the bank, Foundation, and ACES. In ABN AMRO, and subsequently in RBS, we were the leading financiers for India's diamond sector, which in 2013 employed over three million people, contributing six per cent to India's GDP and billions of dollars in exports each year. With a successful consumer and corporate banking business, a profitable treasury and a thriving microfinance portfolio, the bank was a systemically important bank in India. I headed ABN AMRO Bank and subsequently RBS in India from 2007 to 2013, during which period we received high ratings by all three of our regulators – the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), the Bank of England, and De Nederlandsche Bank, the Central Bank of the Netherlands. Equally important, we were ranked by our customers and staff in the top 10 per cent of organizations in India, for customer service and employee engagement.

The horrendous terrorist attack on Mumbai on 26 November 2008 exposed the incompetence and absence of governance and accountability in our administrative and political machinery.

I decided to step forward and use my experience and financial and administrative skills – to make a difference for my city and my country.

I felt that the time had come – for all of us who cared passionately about the idea of India and the future of Indians – to stop sitting in our living rooms, watching TV debates and criticizing the government, and to step up and get actively involved in improving the governance of our country.

With this aim, I took leave from the bank to stand as an independent candidate from the Mumbai South Constituency in the 2009 Lok Sabha elections. As a result of my decision, people all over